



BRAZIL

Capital city: Brasília
Area: 3,286,470 sq miles (8,511,965 sq km)
Population: 179,000,000
Official language: Portuguese
Major religions: Christian 90%, other 10%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: Réal
Adult literacy rate: 82%
Life expectancy: 69 years
People per doctor: 769
Televisions: 215 per 1,000 people

BRAZIL

BOOM AND BUST BEST DESCRIBES the pattern of the economy in Brazil. In the 1960s and 1970s the country enjoyed a period of massive industrial growth. Then the boom ended, Brazil went bust, and the country became the world's greatest debtor. Paying back the loans is now the government's biggest problem. But Brazil has a great supply of natural resources, including gold and iron ore, and mining is one of the country's most important industries. Brazil is both a rich and poor country. Some landowners and business people are extremely wealthy, but most of the rural population is very poor. Although there has been a democratic government since 1985, corruption is still a problem in Brazilian politics.

FOOD FROM BAHIA

The state of Bahia in northeastern Brazil was the first to be colonized by Europeans. Later, black slave cooks created lots of tasty dishes using fish mixed with spices from their native Africa. Along the beaches of Bahia, women still sell these dishes as well as snacks of coconut candies and delicious spicy fish patties.



CARNIVAL

For four days and nights before Lent each year (February or March), it is carnival time in Brazil. People come from all over the world to join the celebration in Rio de Janeiro, where there are street parties, balls, and a contest for the best costume. Day and night the streets are crammed with people in wonderful costumes moving to the rhythm of music. A parade of brightly colored floats, organized by neighborhood samba schools, is the highlight of the carnival.



RELIGION

Almost all Brazilians are Roman Catholic, the religion the Portuguese brought with them, and every town and village has its own patron saint to protect it. Millions of Brazilians also exercise their right to freedom of belief, and worship gods and spirits from African religions. In December and January, for example, people leave gifts of flowers, soap, and fruit on the beaches in honor of *Iemanjá*, the African goddess of the sea, who they hope will grant their wishes for the new year. The goddess is linked with the Catholic Virgin Mary.

ECONOMY

Brazil produces most of its own food and manufactured goods, but needs money to pay off its enormous debts. The country's major exports, some of which are shown here, include coffee, minerals, and airplanes, as well as large numbers of Brazilian cars, which are sold in Argentina. Most of Brazil's manufacturing takes place in a rough triangle formed by the industrial cities of Rio de Janeiro, São Paulo, and Belo Horizonte.



Electrical goods such as refrigerators, washing machines, and food mixers

Leather goods such as bags, shoes, jackets, tennis shoes, and soccer balls



Textiles of cotton and silk, and finished goods including towels and sports clothes



Agricultural produce, including oranges, tangerines, lemons, and limes



GREEN FUEL

In the 1970s, the rising cost of oil forced Brazil to look for an alternative fuel. Researchers came up with ethanol, a fuel made from fermented sugarcane. Ethanol is cheaper than ordinary gasoline and produces less carbon monoxide, which is much better for the environment. Today, about one-third of Brazil's cars run on this "green fuel."